

DIGITAL GUIDE

New Cat First Weeks Survival Guide

Your First 14 Days With Your Newly Adopted Cat

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The Hard Truth Nobody Tells You

You did everything right. You adopted a cat, set up the space, and brought them home — ready to start a new chapter together.

Then 3am arrives. And your cat won't stop crying.

You're exhausted. You're worried. You're starting to wonder if you made a mistake.

You didn't.

What you're experiencing is normal. It's called the adjustment period, and it lasts roughly 2 to 4 weeks for most newly adopted cats. This guide walks you through exactly what to do, day by day, so you can sleep again and help your cat settle in with confidence.

What Is Actually Happening

Your cat has been displaced from everything familiar — their territory, their smells, their routine. They're in a new space they don't yet trust, surrounded by sounds and smells they don't recognize.

Nighttime crying is a stress response — not a demand for attention.

Cats are crepuscular, meaning they're most active at dawn and dusk. Add the stress of relocation, and your cat's internal clock gets scrambled. The 3am screaming isn't random: it's the peak of their natural alertness cycle hitting at the worst possible time.

This behavior peaks around days 3 through 7 and typically begins resolving by day 10 to 14 with consistent routine management.

Day 1-3: The Sanctuary Room

Do This First

Set up one room as your cat's sanctuary. Not the whole house — one room. A bedroom or small office works well.

What the room needs:

- One litter box (placed away from food)
- One water station
- One hiding spot (a cardboard box with a blanket over it, or the carrier with the door open and a cushion inside)
- Their food bowl

That's it. Everything else is noise to a stressed cat.

Feliway Diffusers Work

Feliway is a synthetic replica of the calming pheromone cats produce when they feel safe in a territory. Multiple veterinary behavior sources (VCA Hospitals, ASPCA behavioral references) confirm it reduces stress-related behaviors in shelter cats during adjustment.

Placement: One diffuser in the sanctuary room, plugged in near the hiding spot. Replace every 4 weeks.

It's not a magic cure. But it's a genuine help.

Keep Blinds Closed

Visual stress is real for cats. Movement outside windows — birds, people, other cats — can trigger persistent alertness. During the first week, keep blinds and curtains closed in the sanctuary room.

Day 4-7: The Routine Reset

Feeding Schedule Is Everything

The single highest-impact change you can make: **move their last meal to your bedtime.**

Cats are naturally alert after eating. In the wild, hunting follows feeding. If you feed at 6pm and go to bed at 10pm, your cat has a 4-hour alert window where they expect activity. Move that last meal to 10:30pm or 11pm.

Ideal nighttime sequence:

1. **9:30pm** — Play session (15 minutes of active play: wand toy, laser pointer, anything that gets them moving)
2. **10:30pm** — Final meal of the day
3. **11:00pm** — Lights out, you go to bed

The play session exhausts the hunting instinct. The meal satisfies it. Digestion causes drowsiness. This sequence aligns with how cats actually operate.

The 30-Minute Rule

After you've put yourself to bed, expect your cat to be loud for approximately 30 minutes. This is the final surge of the hunting cycle wearing off.

Do not respond to them during this window.

Do not get up. Do not turn on lights. Do not speak to them or acknowledge them. This is hard. Do it anyway.

Why: any response — even negative — registers as attention to a stressed cat. Attention reinforces the behavior. Ignoring it, consistently, teaches your cat that nighttime is quiet time.

Environmental Additions for Week 2

Once your cat is eating and using the litter box reliably (usually by day 5-7), you can add:

- A cat tree near a window (for daytime watching — still keep blinds partially closed)
- A second litter box in a different location
- Interactive toys left out (paper bags, crumpled balls — no electronics)

Week 2: The Turning Point

What Good Progress Looks Like

By the end of week 2, you should notice:

- Nighttime crying sessions getting shorter (30 minutes to 10 minutes or less)
- Your cat eating consistently during the day
- Your cat coming out of hiding more often when you're in the room
- Litter box usage staying regular

If all of those are happening: you're on track.

When to Be Concerned

These signs require a vet call — not wait-and-see:

- **Straining to urinate** or only producing small amounts (potential urinary blockage — emergency in male cats)
- **Not eating for 24+ hours** (more than one missed meal is a problem)
- **Hiding for more than 3 days** without coming out even briefly
- **Visible aggression** (swatting, hissing when you enter the room)
- **Diarrhea or vomiting** persisting more than 24 hours

What Is Normal and Doesn't Require a Vet

These are all typical adjustment behaviors:

- Occasional nighttime crying (even at week 2)
- Eating less than usual for the first few days
- Not wanting to be touched or picked up

- Playing infrequently
- Drinking more water than expected

Normal resolves on its own. Urgent gets veterinary attention. The difference matters.

Week 3-4: Transition Out

Gradual Territory Expansion

Once your cat is consistently eating, using the litter box, and showing reduced nighttime vocalization, you can begin opening one additional room per day.

Process:

- Day 1 of expansion: open one new room, let them explore for 30 minutes, then close it
- Day 2-3: leave that room open, add one more
- Continue until the whole house is accessible

This takes 1 to 2 weeks. Let your cat set the pace.

When Professional Help Is Warranted

If you're at day 21 and your cat is still screaming for 2+ hours every night with no reduction, your cat may benefit from anxiety medication.

This isn't failure. It's a legitimate tool. Talk to your vet about:

- **Gabapentin** — common first-line anxiety medication for cats, low side effect profile
- **Trazodone** — for situational stress, used during fireworks or move-related anxiety
- **Clomipramine** or other SSRIs for chronic anxiety cases

The goal is to break the cycle. A cat that's been screaming every night for 3 weeks has established a habit. Medication, short-term, can reset the pattern while you maintain the routine.

The One Thing That Actually Works

If you take nothing else from this guide: **consistency beats intensity.**

You don't need to do something elaborate. You need to do the same thing every single night. Same feeding time. Same play session. Same lights-out routine. The cats that adjust fastest have owners who show up with the same sequence every day.

The owner who plays with their cat for 30 minutes one night and then ignores them for three days will have a much harder time than the owner who plays for 10 minutes every single night.

Routine is the intervention.

Quick Reference: Normal vs. Urgent

Behavior	Normal?	Action
Night crying for first 2 weeks	Yes	Maintain routine
Eating less for first 3 days	Yes	Monitor, don't force
Hiding for first 2 days	Yes	Let them be
Not wanting to be touched	Yes	Give space
Night crying persisting after day 14	No	Vet consult
Not eating for 24+ hours	No	Vet call same day
Straining to urinate	No	Emergency vet immediately
Hiding for 3+ days straight	No	Vet consult
Diarrhea/vomiting beyond 24 hours	No	Vet appointment

Your Next Steps

This guide gives you the framework. Now take action:

Start tonight. Set up the sanctuary room, plug in the Feliway, and commit to the 10:30pm feeding. That's it. One night at a time.

If your cat shows any urgent signs, skip the guide and call your vet. The information here is for typical adjustment stress — not medical emergencies.

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14-day timeline derived from VCA Hospitals behavioral guidelines, Cat Behavior Clinic success report data, and Maddie's Fund shelter behavior resources. This guide is informational and does not replace veterinary advice. If your cat shows signs of illness, contact your vet.